

Alchemist's Arsenal

Game design document



Brew the bombs · Arm the heroes · Break the curse

Intended systems

Genre

Target age of players

Intended ESRB / PEGI rating

Projected ship date

Engine

Windows PC (Windows 10 / 11, 64-bit)

Shop management × auto-battler, 2D pixel art
10+

E10+ (Fantasy Violence) / PEGI 7

18 December 2026

Unity 6 (2D, Universal Render Pipeline)

Nuno Gonçalves

Version 1.0 · 22 September 2026

Outline

Game story summary

It was a small spell — a kettle-charm, the kind her grandmother could cast half-asleep. But the witch was not half-asleep. She was angry, and quick, and the words came out crooked. Now someone she loves has fallen into a sleep they will not wake from, and the one thing that can undo it lies deep in the cursed forest beyond her door: a forest full of elemental monsters she cannot face herself.

So she does the one thing she can. She opens a potion shop on the forest's edge and arms the adventurers who can walk the road for her. Every flask she brews becomes a bomb in somebody else's hands. The forest is split into five elemental regions — the **Whispering Woods**, **Cinder Peaks**, **Frostbite Caverns**, **Venom Swamp** and, at the summit, **the Coven's Peak** — and every region pushed back brings her a step closer to the cure, and fills in another line of the sketch in her diary of the thing waiting at the centre.

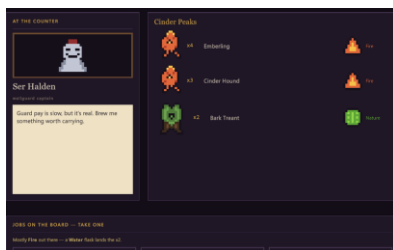
Not every customer is what they seem. An envoy of the Coven starts calling at the counter — “*The Coven noticed your shop. That is not, in itself, good news.*” Breaking the curse at the Coven's Peak finally wakes her loved one, and reveals the truth she never suspected: the curse was a trap all along, set by someone far bigger than a village witch.

Description of gameflow (what is the player's experience)

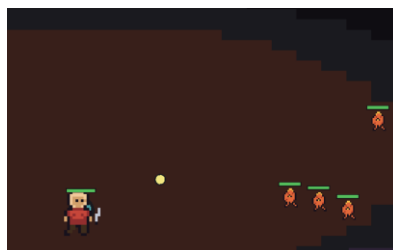
Alchemist's Arsenal fuses a *Papa's Pizzeria*-style shop rush with a *Jacksmith*-style auto-battler. In most shop games the customer walks away and the story ends; here, the player follows their product out of the door, watches it succeed or fail in battle, and comes back the next morning to do better. Every in-game day has three phases:

Phase	What the player does	Mood
Morning — the shop	Take one of three jobs at the counter, then race a real-time clock across the Prep bench, the Cauldron and the Bottling table to brew one elemental bomb for every hero going out.	Frantic hands
Afternoon — the road	The heroes carry those exact flasks into one of five elemental regions and fight waves of monsters on their own, choosing for themselves what to throw at whom. The player watches, and can speed up, pause or call the next wave.	Calm mind
Evening — home	Read the report and the pay, buy upgrades, hire and level heroes, pick tomorrow's party and road, and turn a new page of the diary. Sleeping saves the game.	Quiet

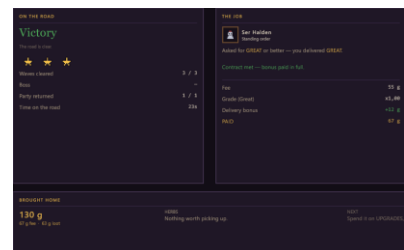
The through-line is **quality**. Every flask is scored from 0 to 100 as it is brewed, and in the afternoon that score becomes damage, ammunition, elemental effectiveness and pay. There is no abstract score screen: a sloppy flask visibly fights worse, and the player sees their morning in the heroes' afternoon.



Morning — a customer, the scouted road and three jobs to choose from.



Afternoon — a flask in flight at a pack of Emberlings.



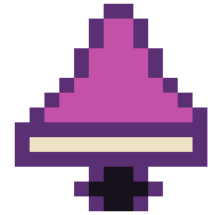
Evening — the road, the job and the pay, accounted for.

Character

Main character: “the Witch”

A village witch who learned her craft at her grandmother’s kitchen table — steady hands, a quick temper, and no business casting anything while angry. She never leaves the shop: the player *is* her, working the counter, the bench and the cauldron. We come to know her through her diary, written in the first person — guilty, stubborn and determined to put right what she broke. *“If I can do it once I can do it five times.”*

The one who sleeps. Never named and never seen awake — the diary only ever calls them “they”. Their silence is the reason for everything; waking them is the goal of the whole game.



The witch's hat — the game's emblem



The Coven Matriarch

Main antagonist: “the Coven Matriarch”

Waiting at the summit of the Coven’s Peak, the Matriarch guards the final region and the last piece of the cure. She is the “thing at the centre” whose portrait the witch assembles in her diary, one arm at a time, as each region falls. Her Coven has its eye on the shop from the very first days, through its envoy at the counter — and when she finally falls, it becomes clear that she was only ever the door to something bigger.

The heroes

Adventurers walk in as customers — each with a favourite element they ask for, a fee and a standard they hold the witch to — and she can hire them onto her roster. On the road each is attuned to one element and has their own way of fighting, so choosing who carries which flask is half the game.

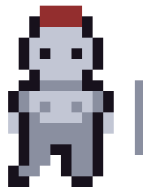


Rookie

your own adventurer

🔥 asks for Fire

“Whatever’s in the flask is what I’ve got out there.”



Ser Halden

wallguard captain

🔥 asks for Fire

“I need something that ends a fight faster than a spear does.”



Mira Thorn

hedge-herbalist

🌿 asks for Nature

“Cut the leaf with the grain, mind. I’ll know if you didn’t.”



Otho Vance

caravan factor

💧 asks for Water

“I don’t buy potions. I buy outcomes.”



Sister Veil

coven envoy

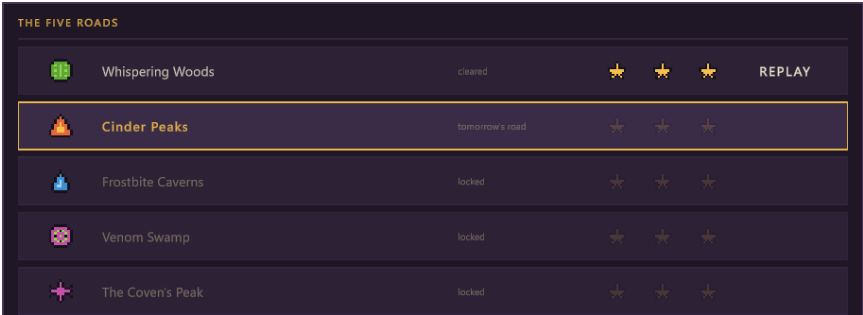
🌟 asks for Arcane

“The Coven noticed your shop. That is not, in itself, good news.”

Gameplay

Progression

The forest road runs through five regions, each themed on an element and each harder than the last. Earning at least one star on a region opens the next, and the witch can push into at most one new region a day — so the Coven’s Peak is five days away at the very least, and most players will take many more, replaying roads, earning gold and building a party strong enough for the summit.



The forest road after day one: the Whispering Woods cleared with three stars, Cinder Peaks next.

#	Region	Element	What waits there
1	Whispering Woods	Nature	Bark Treants, quick Thornlings and a Water-aligned wave of Mossbacks; the Elder Woodwose guards the end. The teaching road — day one has no boss.
2	Cinder Peaks	Fire	Emberling packs and Cinder Hounds, the fastest creatures in the forest.
3	Frostbite Caverns	Water	Swarming Frostkin and slow, heavy Rimebeasts.
4	Venom Swamp	Poison	Snapping Miremaus and hulking Bog Treants.
5	The Coven’s Peak	Arcane	Coven Acolytes, Warded Effigies and the Coven Matriarch herself.

Power grows in three ways, and every one of them is gated so the late game stays hard:

- **Better brewing.** The recipe book grows as regions fall — quick two-step brews, balanced classics and five-step *deep* recipes that hit far harder but eat the morning clock.
- **Better heroes.** Hire a roster of up to five (150, 240, 330, 420 gold) and level each from 1 to 5 (45, 80, 140, 240 gold). Levels are deliberately modest: matching the right hero to the right flask matters more than grinding.
- **A bigger party.** Only one hero goes out at first. A second slot unlocks after Cinder Peaks and a third after Venom Swamp — and every extra hero needs their own brew in the same morning.

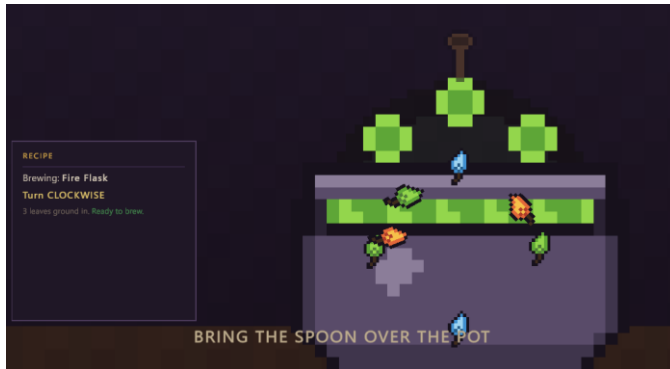
Replayability

- Any cleared region can be replayed for half the fee but full loot — the way to farm gold and rare ingredients, and a safety net so the player can never get stuck.
- Every region is graded out of three stars, so there is always a cleaner run to chase.
- Customers rotate daily, each with their own favourite element, fee and standards, and the three jobs on the board always pull in different directions.
- Fifteen hero perks (five elements × three fighting styles) and a choice of recipes make every party a different puzzle.

Game world

The game lives in two places. **The shop** is warm: candle-gold light on dark wood and ink, a cauldron bubbling in the middle of the room, a bell over the counter and jars of herbs along the bench. **The forest** beyond the door is cold and elemental, and every region wears its element in its palette, its ground and its monsters. The mood is cosy on the surface and uneasy underneath — the shop is a safe, busy place; the forest is where things go wrong.

Everything is hand-made pixel art drawn from a single shared palette of around thirty colours, so the shop, the forest, the heroes and the interface all read as one world.



Herbs swirling in the cauldron mid-brew.

The shop

- **The Counter** — the day's customer, three jobs on the board and a scouting report of every wave on today's road.
- **The Prep bench** — leaves, roots and caps, each with an element, a potency and sometimes a wilt; the mortar and pestle.
- **The Cauldron** — the heart of the room, stirred by hand.
- **The Bottling table** — pour, seal and label.
- **The diary** — an open book on the witch's desk: a picture on the left page, her handwriting on the right.

The forest

- **The forest road** — the map of the five regions, the stars won on each and the choice of where to go tomorrow.
- **Whispering Woods** — mossy clearings and talking trees.
- **Cinder Peaks** — scorched ridges and ash.
- **Frostbite Caverns** — blue ice underground.
- **Venom Swamp** — poisoned, sucking bog.
- **The Coven's Peak** — the violet summit where the Coven waits.



The full party against the Woods' guardian.

Gestalt

Alchemist's Arsenal feels like three small games in one day, and the contrast between them is the point. The **morning is a rush**: the clock is draining, the heat band is drifting, a customer is waiting and the player's hands are full. The **afternoon hands everything over**: the player sits back and watches the heroes use exactly what was made for them — a clean flask landing a double-damage hit, a sloppy one doing half as much, a hero running dry and pulling back. The **evening is quiet**: coins counted, a page of the diary turned, a decision about tomorrow. Frantic hands, calm mind, quiet evening.

What the player should feel

- **Ownership.** There is no abstract score. Every number the heroes deal traces back to something the player did that morning, and the game shows its working: the elemental wheel, the quality grades and even the heroes' reasoning are on screen, never hidden. Easy to read, deep to master.
- **Guilt turning into resolve.** The story is told almost without walls of text — through the diary's illustrations, animated page turns, words that type themselves onto the page, and a sketch of the enemy that assembles itself one piece for every region cleared. The tone is warm and a little melancholy, never grim.
- **A living place.** Every customer speaks in a pitch-shifted, *Animalese*-style voice. The music is adaptive: a cosy shop theme crossfades into a tense forest theme the moment the heroes set off, and every event — a coin, a wax seal, a blast — has its own sound. Not one of these is an audio file: every note, effect and voice is synthesised by the game as it plays.
- **Welcomed, not overwhelmed.** Day one is a guided tutorial: the clock drains slower, the stations open one at a time and an arrow points at the next thing to do. By day two the player is on their own.
- **Rising stakes.** Each region is harder than the last, the party grows, the mornings get more crowded, and the diary's sketch grows more complete — all building to the Coven's Peak and the reveal waiting behind it.

Three moods, one day

	Morning	Afternoon	Evening
Hands	Full — racing the clock	Off — watching, reading	Resting — counting, choosing
Music	Cosy shop theme	Tense forest theme	Cosy shop theme
Colour	Candle gold, dark wood	The region's element	Parchment and ink
Question	"Can I make it well?"	"Did I make the right thing?"	"What do I do tomorrow?"



One flask for every element: Nature, Fire, Water, Poison and Arcane.

Gameplay mechanics

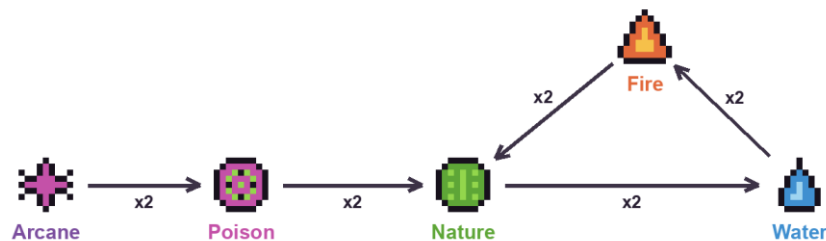


Core mechanics

- **The four stations.** *Counter*: pick one of three jobs — the safe standing order, a guild commission that pays double but refuses a sloppy flask, or the customer's personal favourite, often the wrong element for the road. *Prep*: crush the recipe's leaves into the pot in order, then grind them in the mortar. *Cauldron*: stir by physically turning the spoon around the pot in the direction the recipe demands, keeping the heat inside a band that drifts. *Bottling*: tip a jug to pour to the line without spilling, seal on the beat, and label it right.
- **Quality from 0 to 100.** Every flask starts at 25 (Poor) and every action at every station pushes it up or down. The grade sets the fight:

Grade	Score	Damage	Pay	Elemental bonus	Flasks
Perfect	95–100	×1.20	×1.00 + tip	on	32
Great	80–94	×1.00	×1.00	on	28
Okay	60–79	×0.75	×0.70	on	24
Poor	below 60	×0.50	×0.40	off	20

- **The elemental wheel.** Every monster has an element, and bringing the right flask for the road doubles its damage:



Arrow = attacker deals x2 to defender. The reverse direction deals x0.5. Anything else x1.

- **Recipes.** Each element has several recipes of two to five steps that change the bomb itself — damage, blast radius, range and throw speed. Quick recipes save time; deep recipes hit harder. Potent herbs, and rare ones looted from the forest, push a flask further.
- **Heroes with perks.** Each hero deals +20% damage with a flask of their own element and takes 25% less from it, and fights as a *Skirmisher* (up close), *Marksman* (hangs back for the right target) or *Bulwark* (keeps throwing while hurt). Every perk is worth the same; what changes is where each hero shines. A hero who falls must rest the next day.
- **Heroes who think.** In the fight, heroes are not scripted: each one scores every possible throw — elemental match, distance, how many monsters the blast would catch, its own health — and commits to the best.
- **Real physics.** Herbs float and swirl in the cauldron under real forces and torque from the stirring; the mortar's seeds and the bottling pour are real rigid bodies; flasks fly on true ballistic arcs and blasts knock monsters back.

Enemies

The cursed forest is thick with elemental creatures, and every region's monsters share its element — which is exactly why the right flask matters. They arrive in waves the Counter scouts in advance, so the player always knows what is coming and has to decide what to brew for it. Most creatures walk straight at the heroes and strike on contact, and most regions mix in a wave of a different element that punishes a single-element plan — one flask rarely covers a whole road.



Treantkin

Bark Treant · Thornling · Mossback · Bog Treant

Nature / Water
34–70 HP

Rooted and patient — except the Thornlings, which close the gap fast.



Emberlings

Emberling · Cinder Hound

Fire
40–55 HP

Fire packs; the Cinder Hound is the quickest thing in the forest.



Frostkin

Frostkin · Rimebeast

Water
50–80 HP

Water swarms, and Rimebeasts that soak up punishment.



Miremaws

Miremaw

Poison
44 HP

Poison bog-mouths that hunt in fours.



The Coven's own

Coven Acolyte · Warded Effigy

Arcane / Poison
55–90 HP

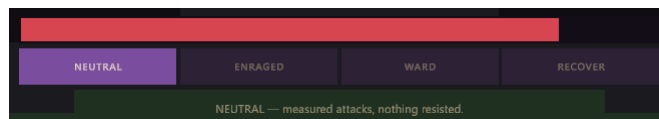
Arcane servants; the Effigies are the toughest regular foes.

Bosses: the forest's guardians



The Coven Matriarch

Each region ends at a guardian holding part of the cure — among them the **Elder Woodwose** (Nature, 300 HP) at the end of the Whispering Woods and the **Coven Matriarch** (Arcane, 520 HP) at the summit. Bosses are not scripted either: they constantly weigh their own health, the damage they have just taken and how hard any single element is pressing them, and shift between four phases the player can read on screen.



- **Neutral** — measured, long-range Arcane Bolts; nothing resisted. The boss's default while healthy.
- **Enraged** — as its health drops the boss turns aggressive, adding a heavy close-range Coven Slam to its bolts.
- **Elemental Ward** — hammer a boss with one element and it raises a ward against exactly that element, answering with a Ward Pulse. The heroes have to switch flasks — and the player learns to brew more than one element for a boss day.
- **Recovering** — badly hurt and under heavy fire, it stops attacking to recover. The window to finish it.

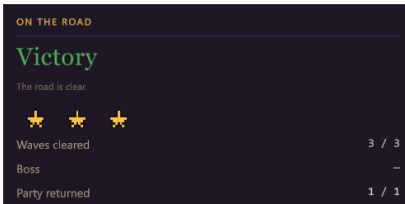
Guardian attack	Element	Reach	Damage	Used in
Arcane Bolt	Arcane	Long range, small blast	10	Neutral, Enraged
Coven Slam	Nature	Close range, wide blast	18	Enraged
Ward Pulse	Water	A burst around itself	8	Elemental Ward

Bonus

For players who want more than the road to the Coven’s Peak, the game rewards mastery and curiosity in ways that never lock the story away.

Three stars on every road

Every expedition is graded: one star for bringing the road home, one for bringing every hero back, and one for felling the region’s guardian. Perfectionists will return to earlier regions with a stronger party to fill in every star.



A three-star day in the Evening report

The diary

Diary entries unlock from milestones — the first morning, each region cleared, the first Perfect potion, each rare ingredient discovered — and every one is illustrated. Filling the diary completes the story, and the sketch of the thing at the centre gains a piece for every region the witch pushes back.

Rare ingredients

Monsters sometimes drop rare herbs — **Emberleaf**, **Frostmoss**, **Cinder Heart**, **Venom Sac** and the **Coven Sigil**. Carried home, they appear on the prep bench as ingredients stronger than anything the witch can buy, feeding the forest’s spoils straight back into the next morning’s brew.



Herbs of every element — rare ones brew stronger flasks.

Rare herb	Dropped by	Where	Chance
Emberleaf	Bark Treant	Whispering Woods	40%
Frostmoss	Mossback, Frostkin	Whispering Woods, Frostbite Caverns	30–35%
Cinder Heart	Emberling	Cinder Peaks	15%
Venom Sac	Miremaw	Venom Swamp	40%
Coven Sigil	Warded Effigy	The Coven’s Peak	50%

A complete roster

Collect a hero for every element — five heroes, fifteen possible perks — and raise them all to level five.

Perfect flasks and the Guild

A Perfect potion earns a tip on top of the fee. The Guild commission pays far more for a Great flask and halves the pay if the witch falls short — the high-stakes job for confident brewers, and a reason to keep sharpening every station long after the story is done.

Money

Alchemist's Arsenal will be released **free on itch.io** as a complete game — no ads, no microtransactions and nothing locked behind a payment. Every region, hero, recipe and page of the story is unlocked by playing.

Players who enjoy it can leave an optional **pay-what-you-want tip** on the itch.io page. Tips support further development and never unlock anything in-game: a player who pays nothing gets exactly the same game as one who pays.

Distribution

- A Windows **installer** (built with Inno Setup) and a portable zip, both hosted on the itch.io page.
- Updates delivered through itch.io and the itch desktop app, so existing players are kept up to date automatically.
- Saves are stored locally and survive updates.

Future content

Free updates may add new regions, heroes, recipes and chapters of the diary. The ending deliberately leaves room for more: breaking the curse reveals it was a trap set by someone far bigger, and that is a story worth continuing.

Why free

As an independent first release, the aim is players and feedback rather than revenue. A free game on itch.io reaches the widest audience, invites honest reviews and builds an audience for whatever comes next — and keeping the game free of pay-to-win mechanics keeps the focus where it belongs: on skill at the bench and good judgement about who to send down the road.